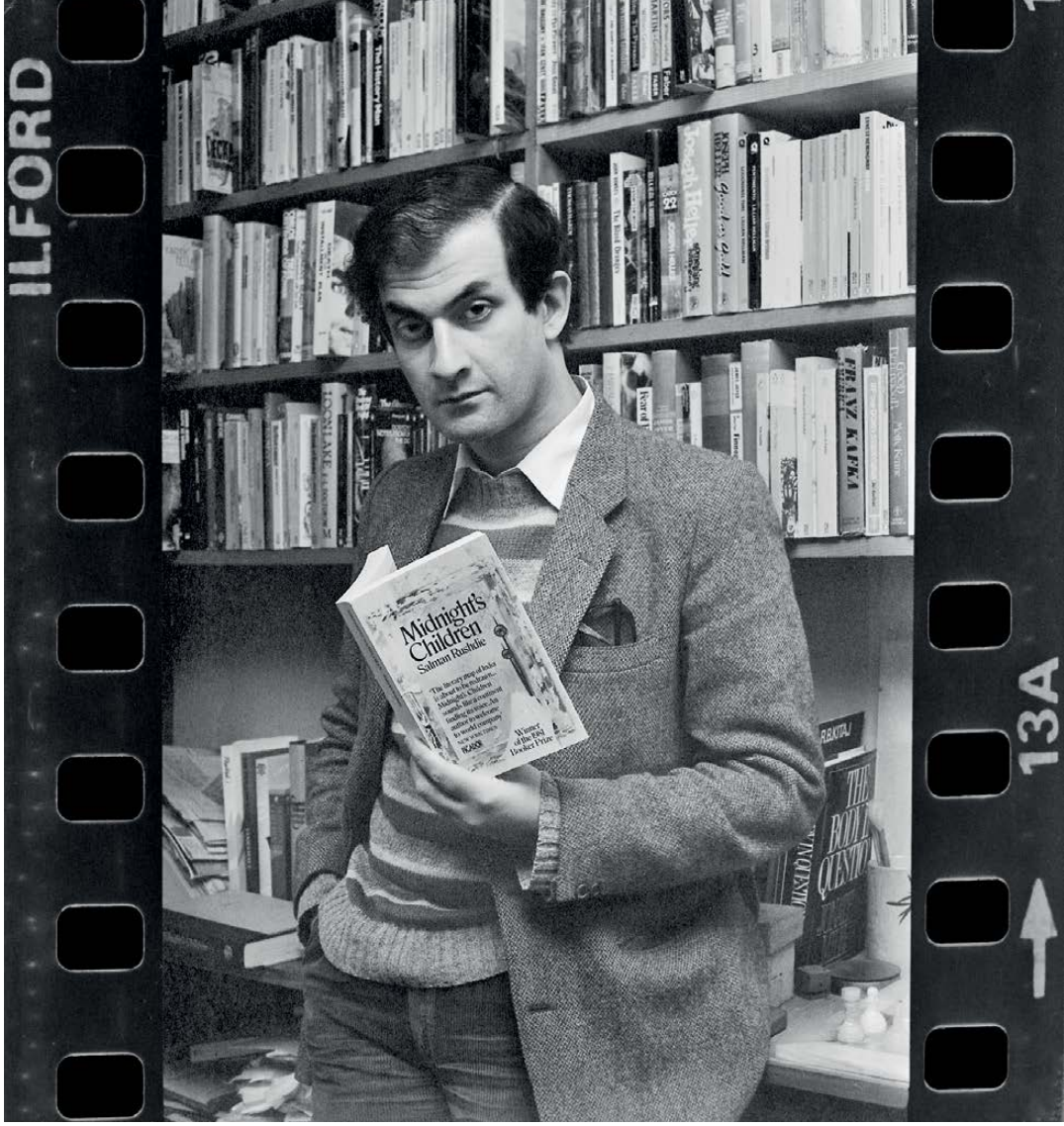
49th ANNIVERSARY



WEAVING MAGIC Rushdie in 1982 with a copy of his Booker-winning *Midnight's Children*

ALAMY

INDIAN WRITING IN ENGLISH

REVENGE OF THE NATIVE

Rushdie lit the way but Indian writing in English has taken a life of its own in the past few decades, with translated Indian fiction most recently having its moment in the sun

BY AMIT DIXIT

When the 34-year-old Salman Rushdie published his second novel, *Midnight's Children*, in 1981, it catapulted him—and Indo-Anglian writing (or Indian Writing in English, as it's now called)—into the global literary limelight. Not only did the novel about a fledgling nation grappling with the aftermath of Independence win the Booker Prize that year, it bagged the Booker of Bookers in 1993 to mark the 25th anniversary of the prize, and then the Best of the Booker on the award's 45th anniversary in 2008.

Midnight's Children marked a clear departure from the Indian English novels of the past, which were often characterised by a stiff, derivative style. Rushdie's stylistic device of choice was 'magical realism', which has since become his calling card. Meanwhile, his international celebrity status gave an entire generation of budding Indian writers the confidence to make a career out of the writerly life, something that was unthinkable earlier. More importantly, publishers saw enough commercial potential in the enterprise to back them.